DAILY READING • 样张

The Island Survey

2026-11-03 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 592 词 · 5 段

短文

The supply boat made its weekly cruise back to the mainland at four, and I stayed at the rail until the island shrank to a dark line. The island was remote — four hours of open water — and from the sea it looked like a jewel, a green ridge with grassy slopes that held the last light. Chen, the only ranger, met me at the dock with a handshake shorter than I expected. Behind his cabin he kept a small plot of beans and peppers. “Not much here,” he said, in a casual way that suggested he had said it many times. I told him I had nine days, a schedule I could not change, and a clear vision of the survey. He looked at the constant wind bending the grass and said, “You’ll see.”

The interior was another country. The path climbed through ferns, then opened onto a plateau where the wind never stopped. My thesis was simple: rats had come ashore from a wrecked trawler, and their invasion was moving inland. Consequently, the survival of two ground-nesting birds depended on how quickly we could find the nests. I had a mathematical model that predicted the spread, and I spent two days trying to evaluate whether the numbers matched the ground. They did not. Early detection was the only effective approach, but the logic of my plan assumed a team of six. I had one observer — myself — and a notebook that was already damp.

On the third morning the generator died. Something had chewed through a circuit in the control box, and the smell was awful: burnt plastic and old oil. “Goodness,” Chen said, the first time I had heard him sound surprised. We could not bypass the damage, so he dragged the machine onto the platform and knelt underneath it, working by feel, his stiff knees cracking on the boards. While he worked he told me he had initiated the rat survey himself two years earlier, before anyone would fund it. He had handled the disposal of old fuel cans ever since. I felt uneasy watching him. His tone stayed calm, and he assured me we would have power by dark. He was right.

The storm came on the sixth night. The radio put the intensity at force nine, and by ten the rain had begun to rip at the tarpaulin over the water tank. I clung to the rail while Chen checked

the moorings. When the wind withdrew at dawn, the beach was littered with debris and one dead shearwater. We took shelter in the cabin, and he made tea. That was when he began to talk — about the wreck, about the rats, about the twenty years he had spent on this rock. His accent thickened as he spoke, and I had to enquire twice before I understood him. What he said impressed me more than any paper I had read.

Afterward, I rewrote the thesis. The novelty of the model wore off quickly once I saw how much depended on one man's memory of a beach. The cabin was not luxurious — no hot water, and a paraffin lamp as the sole source of light — but the arrangement was beneficial in a way I had not expected. The stake was not my degree; it was whether the birds would still be there in five years. I quoted Chen in the final chapter, and I forged a friendship that outlasted the survey. In the realm of ecology, I wrote, a remote island teaches you how little you know.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

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译文

补给船在四点完成了它每周一次返回大陆的航行，我一直站在栏杆边，直到岛缩成一条黑线。这座岛很偏远——四小时的开阔水域——从海上看，它像一颗宝石，一道绿色山脊，长满草的坡地托住最后一点天光。陈是岛上唯一的护林员，他在码头和我握手，比我预想的要短。他的小屋后面，他种了一小块豆子和辣椒。“这儿没什么东西，”他说，语气随意，像是这句话已经说过很多遍。我告诉他我有九天时间、一个改不了的日程，以及对这次调查清晰的设想。他看着不停弯折草叶的风，说：“你会明白的。”

岛的腹地是另一个国家。小路穿过蕨类植物向上爬，然后在一片高地上展开，那里的风从不停歇。我的论文很简单：老鼠从一艘失事的拖网渔船上了岸，它们的入侵正向内陆推进。因此，两种在地面筑巢的鸟能否存活，取决于我们能多快找到鸟巢。我有一个预测扩散范围的数学模型，花了两天评估这些数字是否与实地相符。它们并不相符。早期发现是唯一有效的办法，但我计划里的逻辑假设了一支六人团队。我只有一个观察者——我自己——和一本已经受潮的笔记本。

第三天早上，发电机坏了。有什么东西咬穿了控制箱里的一处电路，气味很难闻：烧焦的塑料和陈旧的机油。“天呐，”陈说，这是我第一次听他显得吃惊。我们没法绕过这个损坏，于是他把机器拖到平台上，跪在下面凭手感修，僵硬的膝盖压在木板上咔咔作响。他一边修一边告诉我，两年前他就自己发起了这项老鼠调查，那时还没有人愿意出钱。从那以后，处理旧油罐一直是他的活。看着他，我心里不安。他的语气一直很平静，还向我保证天黑前会有电。他说对了。

暴风雨在第六个晚上来了。收音机把强度定为九级，到十点，雨已经开始撕扯水箱上的防水布。我抓紧栏杆，陈去检查系泊。天亮时风退去了，沙滩上散落着碎片和一只死去的海燕。我们躲进小屋，他泡了茶。就是那时他开始说话的——说那艘沉船，说老鼠，说他在这个石头上度过的二十年。他说话时口音变重了，我得问两遍才听懂。他说的那些，比我读过的任何论文都更让我触动。

后来，我重写了论文。一旦我看到有多少东西取决于一个人对一片沙滩的记忆，模型的新奇感很快就消退了。小屋并不豪华——没有热水，一盏煤油灯是唯一的光源——但这种安排以一种我没预料到的方式对我有益。赌注不是我的学位，而是五年后那些鸟还在不在。我在最后一章引用了陈的话，也建立了一段比这次调查更长的友谊。在生态学这个领域里，我写道，一座偏远的岛会教你知道自己懂得多么少。